

Cowon Q5W

Heavy Duty Pocket Entertainer

Cowon is a brand that we respect and rightly so; their D2 and i7 were two PMPs that still stand out amidst all the competition. However there was something missing; Cowon has a video PMP in the A30 series but other than a 4-inch screen there's nothing unique the A3 and Creative's Zen Vision W is a serious threat. And we like a bigger screen; the bezel on the A30 is something that wastes too much of space with fancy large buttons. Enter the Q5W, Cowon's attempt at cramming aboard every possible feature a PMP user might want. We could fill a page with this thing's specifications alone; but we're not about to.

The Q5W is large; much bigger than most PMPs and heavy. It's solidly built and the dark navy body goes well with the silver-grey bezel that runs around all four sides. Everything about the design bespeaks restraint and with its very sophisticated look sans any sort of buttons on the front bezel, the Q5W looks intimidating. For starters it's got a colossal five inch touchscreen that displays 16 million colours and has a whopping resolution of 800 x 480 pixels. And it gets better. The Q5W actually runs Windows Mobile 5.0, which means it's a full-fledged PDA.

WLAN means you can get online and surf, Internet Explorer for WM is part of the package. If you install MS Office for WM you have the option of working with documents, spreadsheets and PowerPoint presentations. A mini-USB port connects to a computer while a full size

USB (type A) port has been provided to enable connecting with USB keyboards. This is a powerful connectivity option since this is one feature that most PDAs lack; which make them rather useless for anyone needing to do a lot of typing. Bluetooth is present and wireless headsets are supported.

The menu system is very simple; there are two side-bars which hold all the options and finger touches work as well as the stylus. The option on the left of the screen is the main one; clicking on this will open up sub-options on the right side. Holding the Q5W in both hands means these left and right menus coincide with both your thumbs; obviously something Cowon did deliberately and once you use this PMP you'll slowly appreciate the genius of the navigation system.

An AV cable with both Component and Composite connects is provided as is a remote control unit. This coupled with the fact that the Q5W plays .AVI, .DivX, .XviD, .WMV and MPEG4 files out of the box means that you have your very own portable DVD player. Copying a movie to the Q5W is as simple as a drag and drop and there's no encoding involved, like some of the other brands that use proprietary formats. Even audio formats are supported in plenty – MP3, WMA, OGG, WAV, FLAC, APE and MPC files formats are supported. This makes the Q5W immensely versatile and somewhat of a rarity in this format-restricted world of digital entertainment.



We tested the Q5W as an MP3 player first and were pleasantly surprised with its quality. Even on our reference headphones the Q5W produces accurate and detailed mid-range and highs, while the bass is tight and impact full with nary a hint of flab. We like the tonal neutrality; and with support for playback of .FLAC files, audiophiles will not be disappointed. People who really like movies on the go will also not find anything worthy of complaining about; the screen is as large as possible while retaining some sense of portability.

Used as a PIM or for browsing; the Q5W has all of WM5's flaws and all its merits. It's a very feature rich device that delivers the performance goodies as well. If there is one thing that the Q5W does fall short in; its in the expectation that Cowon had that a fully converged, all-in-one device will appeal to everybody. The concept is flawed; not the device. Someone wanting a simple music player could look elsewhere since there are cheaper alternatives around. Anyone looking at portability will definitely skip the Q5W; as this heavyweight is anything but compact.

Priced at Rs 32,000 for the 80 GB version the Q5W is certainly interesting enough to consider despite the fact that its more than double the price of serious PMPs like Cowon's own D2 and Apples iPod Touch. No other PMP has all its features; and chances are none will. For those looking for a terrific PMP with a lot of additional features and a wonderful touchscreen the Cowon Q5W is just what you're looking for; irrespective of the price tag. If you're wondering whether its worth it or not; chances are it won't be to you; ditch the idea and buy a regular PMP.

Specifications

CPU – Alchemy AU1250 600 MHz, 128 MB DDR2 RAM, WinCE 5.0 Pro, Screen – 5.0-inch, 800 x 480 pixels, 16.7-million colours, Contrast Ratio-500:1, WLAN, Bluetooth support, 80 GB, 1.8-inch HDD

Contact: Lipap Systems Pvt. Ltd.
Phone No: 022-40032653
Email: iaudio@lipap.com
Website: www.cowonindia.in
Price: Rs 32,000

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Nokia E66

E Series Meets The Slider Craze

Gone are the days when Nokia used to make great, ugly looking phones. The E66 may be part of their business class E series but it's a serious multimedia phone as well. This slider phone is the non-QWERTY equivalent of the E71, which we reviewed earlier and found to have a cramped keypad. The off-white body finish is attractive but not overly so. The rear cover is solid steel which imparts both weight as well as a rugged feel. The front bezel is rimmed in chrome; the buttons on the front are transparent fibre on chrome which blends in with the bezel. The slider is built to last; this phone feels extremely solid in-hand and even the finish exudes a quality feel. The screen at 2.4-inches is crisp and bright; although we do not like the animated style of icons which Nokia has been persisting with.

The outer keys are built well, but not bevelled which may cause a few false key presses; nothing serious though. Dedicated hard shortcut keys for emails, contacts and calendar functions have been provided. The call accept/reject buttons are large and easy to use. The four-way joystick and middle button are large and comfortable to use; ergonomics are top class. Key backlighting is very good. The number pad is well laid out and the keys are very large which is good news for ham handed blokes. We feel this keypad would suit all people; top points to Nokia here. SMS junkies will have a good time and none of us had any issues whatsoever with the number pad. However for a business phone we

have to admit some users may need a full QWERTY keypad; in which you may want to look at the E71. The volume buttons on the side are large and easy to use.

Nokia has included additional goodies like Bluetooth with A2DP support, WLAN and GPS. The E66 comes with 110 MB of inbuilt memory and this is expandable via microSD. All this makes the E66 a loaded device. A 2.5-mm jack has been provided for the handsfree kit; we feel Nokia goofed up in not offering a standard 3.5-mm jack since many people will want to use their own earphones for music and such. The quality of accessories is also top class.

Music quality if the E66 is strictly okay; we feel the earplugs could be the culprit but with the lack of any 3.5-mm connectivity we could not use our reference earplugs to test this. However due to the restriction of earplugs do not buy this phone if music is your thing; there are far better options around. The 3.2 megapixel camera is strictly so-so; there are much better 3.2 MP units around. The flash is substandard; but to the E66s defence it's a business phone. So the camera part is strictly cosmetic.

The GPS part of the phone is something we like; you can work offline using Nokia maps' preloaded maps or go online with either Nokia Maps or Google Maps (which is also provided). However once started we had a problem getting Google Maps to close and the application could not even be ended. A firmware patch should address this problem; but we had to restart



the phone to shut off Google Maps. The phone has an inbuilt accelerometer which Nokia has been including in all their higher range of phones. Although this gets annoying at times to find the screen has re-oriented this can be switched off. All considered we feel it's a decent inclusion.

Despite the fact that the E66 shares the same hardware under the hood as the Nokia N95 8 GB we found this phone to be sluggish; some applications take awhile to open and running any heavy multimedia tasks means the phone will take awhile to switch to other tasks. In-call quality is good and the E66 has a good inbuilt antenna that offers good reception and voice quality. The voice quality

while on loud-speaker is good too. The quality on the handsfree unit is decent; we've seen better from Nokia. The 1,000 mAh battery is acclaimed by Nokia to give seven and a half hours of talk-time; we measure this at around five hours – not bad.

Overall the E66 impresses but we're more concerned about its target audience. Hardcore business users will look for something a little more err hardcore, while multimedia users will find performance of the multimedia player and camera components lacking. So the E66 gets stuck between a rock and a hard place; or more aptly between a businessman and a college goer. At Rs 23,689;

its well priced. Anyone willing to look past its few (albeit noticeable) flaws will be rewarded with a feature rich, superbly built and long lasting device.

Specifications

CPU - 369 MHz ARM 11, RAM - 128 MB, Screen - 2.4-inches, 16M colours, 240 x 320 pixels, Weight - 121 grams, 3.2 MP camera with flash, 2 GB microSD card bundled

Contact: Nokia India Pvt. Ltd.
Phone no: 011-30303838
Website: www.nokia.com
Price: Rs 23,689

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★